

THE ELDER FUTHARK

TWENTY-FOUR RUNES · THREE AETTIR · THEIR NAMES AND MEANINGS

The Elder Futhark is the oldest form of the runic alphabet, used across the Germanic world. Its twenty-four runes are arranged in three groups of eight, called aettir (singular: aett), each associated with a divine principle. Each rune carries a name, a phonetic value, and a cluster of meanings – practical, symbolic, and emotional. The emotional reading is not separate from the practical one. The runes were understood to describe the inner state of things as much as their outer form.

FIRST AETT · FREYR'S AETT · THE FORCES OF CREATION AND SUSTENANCE

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FEHU

F — cattle,
wealth

Abundance, fortune, nourishment. The energy that sustains what lives.

Emotional: the warmth of provision, fulfillment, what feeds.

Also: that which flows and therefore can be lost.

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URUZ

U — auroch,
wild ox

Primal strength, raw vitality, the force of untamed nature.

Emotional: courage before it is named, endurance in the body, the will that pushes without asking why.

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THURISAZ

Th — giant,
thorn

Conflict and protection both. The force that cuts.

Emotional: the moment of confrontation you cannot avoid, the crisis that clarifies, defense through destruction.

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ANSUZ

A — god,
Odin, breath

Divine speech, wisdom received. The rune of breath, word, and revelation.

Emotional: inspiration, the feeling of being spoken to by something larger than yourself.

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RAIDHO

R — ride,
journey

Movement with purpose. The right path taken in the right way.

Emotional: direction, the alignment of will and action, the soul in motion toward what it knows.

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KENAZ

K / C —
torch, craft

Controlled fire, knowledge, craft. The light held against darkness.

Emotional: clarity that comes from within, the warmth of making, creativity as discipline.

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GEBO

G — gift,
exchange

The gift freely given, partnership, the exchange that binds both parties.

Emotional: generosity as power, the voluntary sacrifice, love as gift. Cannot be reversed.

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WUNJO

W / V — joy,
tribe

Harmony, belonging, the tribe at peace. Shared happiness.

Emotional: the feeling of rightness in one's place, kinship, the relief of being held by others.

SECOND AETT · HAGAL'S AETT · THE FORCES OF DISRUPTION AND TRANSFORMATION

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HAGALAZ

H — hail,
disruption

The storm that comes regardless of will. Disruption from outside.

Emotional: the crisis you did not choose, transformation through destruction, what cannot be resisted.

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NAUTHIZ

N — need,
necessity

Constraint, necessity. The fire made by friction. That which must be.

Emotional: hardship that reveals strength, endurance, the compressed energy of what cannot be avoided.

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ISAZ

I — ice,
stillness

Suspension, the frozen moment. Nothing moves.

Emotional: the patience that is not passive, clarity through cold, the self held in stillness before something breaks.

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JERA

J / Y — year,
harvest

Cycles, the earned reward, the natural order of time.

Emotional: patience rewarded, the knowledge that seasons turn, what was planted returns when the time is right.

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EIHWAZ

Ei — yew
tree, axis

The axis between life and death. The tree that is both.

Emotional: transformation, the paradox of endings that are beginnings, resilience in the deepest dark.

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PERTHRO

P — lot cup,
mystery

Fate, chance, the hidden. What is held in the container you cannot see into.

Emotional: the unknown that shapes you, the peace of accepting what is not yours to control.

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ALGIZ

Z / R — elk,
protection

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SOWILO

S — sun,
victory

Protection, sanctuary, the reach upward toward the divine.

Emotional: the feeling of being held by something beyond you, the refusal to be consumed, connection that defends.

The sun. Victory, wholeness, vital force. The self in full light.

Emotional: clarity, the will toward life, the self that does not apologise for existing. Cannot be reversed.

THIRD AETT · TYR'S AETT · THE FORCES OF ORDER, SACRIFICE, AND BECOMING



TIWAZ
T — Tyr,
justice

Sacrifice for principle, honor, the right action regardless of cost.

Emotional: the courage to lose something for what is right, the wound that was worth it, duty as meaning.



BERKANO
B — birch,
renewal

New growth, renewal, nurturing. The beginning after the end.

Emotional: the mother's care, what grows when it is given what it needs, the tender courage of starting again.



EHWAZ
E — horse,
partnership

Partnership, movement in harmony. The bond between horse and rider.

Emotional: cooperation, loyalty, the movement that comes from trust between two who know each other.



MANNAZ
M — man,
humanity

The self in relation to others. The human condition.

Emotional: self-awareness without illusion, kinship, the dignity of being one among many, the examined self.



LAGUZ
L — water,
lake, flow

Flow, the unconscious, intuition. The deep that pulls.

Emotional: the feeling-knowledge that cannot be fully spoken, emotion as information, what cannot be held but shapes everything.



INGWAZ
Ing — Ing,
inner work

Completion of inner work, gestation, potential held before release.

Emotional: the quiet before emergence, what is becoming but not yet — the seed in winter. Release comes when the work is done.



DAGAZ
D — day, dawn

Breakthrough, the threshold between dark and light. The instant everything changes.

Emotional: awakening, the moment of transformation, hope that does not wait but arrives as fact. Cannot be reversed.



OTHALA
O —
ancestral
land, home

Heritage, belonging, what is inherited from those who came before.

Emotional: the roots that hold, the love of what was given to you without being asked, home as identity.

READING THE RUNES

NOTES ON INTERPRETATION · THE THREE AETTIR · THE PHASE RING

THE THREE AETTIR — WHAT EACH GOVERNS

FREYR'S AETT (I–VIII)

The forces of creation, sustenance, and exchange. What nourishes and connects. The outer world and its gifts. How we survive and relate to others.

HAGAL'S AETT (IX–XVI)

The forces of disruption and transformation. What breaks us open. The middle passage between what we were and what we must become. Crisis that teaches.

TYR'S AETT (XVII–XXIV)

The forces of order, sacrifice, and becoming. What we choose, what we build, what we pass on. The self in relation to principle, time, and heritage.

HOW TO READ A RUNE

Each rune has at minimum three layers: its concrete meaning (cattle, ice, torch), its symbolic meaning (wealth, stillness, knowledge), and its emotional or inner meaning — the feeling-state it describes. The emotional layer is not separate from the other two. The runes were understood as forces present in the world and in the self at the same time.

When reading a rune, ask: what is the outer form, what does it point to, and what does it feel like from the inside? A reading that stops at the symbol misses what the rune is for.

REVERSED RUNES (MERKSTAVE)

Not all runes have a reversed meaning — Gebo, Sowilo, Jera, Ingwaz, Dagaz, and Isaz cannot be reversed by their nature (symmetrical, or representing forces with no opposite). For runes that can be reversed, the reversed position suggests the shadow quality of the same force: the gift withheld, the strength turned inward destructively, the harvest that does not come.

A reversed rune does not mean the opposite. It means the same force blocked, delayed, or turned against the one who carries it.

DIRECTION OF READING

Elder Futhark runes were typically written left to right but were sometimes reversed or mirrored. The order of the three aettir is consistent across all known sources. The name "Futhark" comes from the first six runes in order: Fehu, Uruz, Thurisaz, Ansuz, Raidho, Kenaz.

THE PHASE RING · MOON AND SUN POSITIONS

The centre ring of the runic box shows phases of the moon and sun as they appear through a cycle. Each position describes a state of light — from darkness through partial to full, and back. In the context of the runes, the phase ring marks the condition under which the runes are read.

NEW MOON	WAXING CRESCENT	FIRST QUARTER	WAXING GIBBOUS	FULL MOON	WANING GIBBOUS
					
LAST QUARTER	WANING CRESCENT	FULL SUN	SUN RISING	DAWN	DUSK

The new moon and full sun are opposite states. The dawn positions — where darkness yields to light — are transitional. The ritual described in the Archive documents references a moment of transition, not of stasis.

THREE RUNES THAT CANNOT BE REVERSED

Gebo (X): The gift has no shadow form because a gift freely given cannot be taken back without becoming something else entirely. Once given, it is no longer yours to reverse.

Sowilo (S): The sun does not have an opposite. Darkness is only the sun's absence.

Dagaz (D): The moment of breakthrough cannot be unreachable. Once the threshold is crossed, there is no path back — only a new beginning.

These three are said to be the runes of things that, once in motion, complete themselves.